

Here's the letter with that addition placed at the end, just before the closing—where it lands as a final, honest expression of love and frustration:

****Good morning Daddy,****

This message isn't fully polished, but I felt the need to soften my words and clarify where they come from.

****Before you read further, I want to say this:**** What follows is long and covers a lot of ground—some of it difficult. It touches on my earlier rude comment, on money, on being gay, and on disappointments I've carried quietly for years. I'm not sending this to hurt you. I'm sending it because I may not have many opportunities to say these things piece by piece, and I'd rather you understand where I stand than have you guess or assume the worst.

I trust you to do what you've always done well: set emotions aside, take your time, and think through things calmly. That's something positive I learned from you and still hold onto. So please read this in that spirit—not as an attack, but as your son trying to be honest with his father.

I also know human beings tend to remember the bad more than the good, especially when emotions are involved. So please keep in mind: for every difficult or hurtful thing in this message, there are countless good things you've done and continue to do. I carry those with me too.

****I worry about you.****

Just as parents worry about their children, children worry about their parents. I think about where your headspace is—not just whether you'll have financial security in retirement, but what you're still reaching for. Whether you're preparing to retire and simply wind down, or whether you remember that as a father five times over and now a grandfather four times over, with more to come by God's grace, more is expected of you than simply the basics.

You had immense privilege:

- Early childhood education by sitting in your father's classes—a strong indicator of future educational attainment
- Scholarships from Nigerian communities and the government
- Attending UI when it was on par with today's top-ranking universities
- Becoming one of the most highly educated people in the country, whose voice already commands respect

I wonder if you ever saw these as privileges, or just as things that happened. I wonder what ambitions you held beyond becoming a professor and chairing a department. I wonder what happened along the way.

****About my earlier comment regarding the toilet—****

I apologize. Despite the observation being rooted in something real for me, it was extremely rude to share it that way.

Lee Kuan Yew, in **From Third World to First**, wrote about using the state of public toilets as a metric for judging how developed a place is. When he landed somewhere, he'd look at the toilets and know what to expect of the people. I've found this holds true for families too. But that's an internal metric—not something I should have thrown at you the way I did.

****About money and control—****

When you give, please give freely and be happy, or don't give at all. Using money as a means of control is something I'd ask you to grow out of.

I want to be clear: I am genuinely grateful for this trip and grateful that you wanted to help make it possible. Thank you. But my arrangement was with Ogoma. She assured me she wasn't in financial distress using her credit card to fund my trip. So as far as I understood it, Ogoma funded my trip, not you. If she took your money, that's something to discuss with her—she should be able to return it within 24 hours.

****About why I hold certain views—and how long I've held them:****

Growing up, you were my hero. The paragon of integrity. I assumed you had good reasons for keeping the family in Nigeria, for the choices you made, for not teaching us our mother tongue. I assumed there was a larger plan I couldn't yet see.

That changed during one of my first exam seasons in the UK, when you and Mummy came over making a fuss over Chidi and me. It struck me then that neither of you fully understood what you were doing as parents, and that you didn't have good mentors guiding you either.

You hadn't done the geopolitical and policy research that more prepared parents do when deciding where to send their children.

You hadn't understood what well-positioned families actually send their children to university for—not just to get degrees, but to make friends with children from similarly minded families, to learn to be agents who shape the world rather than react to it. The degrees themselves are basic; the real value is in relationships with people who will go on to influence how things work.

You showed up at a critical time in the academic calendar without understanding the nature of competition in modern advanced countries. How cutthroat it is. The pressure and extremes people go through just to get basic white-collar jobs.

And how could you have known? Since your first job offer at UCH, you never challenged yourself to go higher. Perhaps it became too difficult—being a father and husband to a wife who was growing mentally ill while pursuing her own legitimate career ambitions with her limited business education and global exposure, all while raising five children. Perhaps you checked out at some point. I don't know.

I still highly respect Mummy because of her ambition and humility. All of us siblings think she needs help.

I'm not sure what my siblings think about you. But I gave you both a vote of no confidence that day—in your ability to prepare me for the modern world, especially as a gay man—and I decided I was on my own.

****About Bristol—****

Thinking back, I might be in a better position to help you now if you and Mummy had trusted my judgment and let me study Computer Science at the University of Bristol.

I had chosen Bristol because:

- It was cheaper than Queen Mary in both fees and rent
- Northern England is known for being more down-to-earth; loneliness and isolation would have been less severe
- It had over 95% internship placement rates with top firms like Google from first year

But at the time, I still believed you both knew what you were doing. When you said no—not UCL, not Bristol, Queen Mary because it's closer and we need you to emotionally support your brother—I said okay.

Had you been present in our lives during secondary school, you would have known how absurd this "emotional support" arrangement with Chidi actually was. Chidi tried to be the cool kid and was friends with bullies. My very first interaction with him at school, he threw the lunch money you gave him to hold for us onto the floor, and I had to pick it up. That set the tone for our entire secondary school relationship.

It was so hurtful that I decided Ugo would never experience a brother like that. But as a practicing Catholic and young gay boy figuring out his life—watching his parents do the whole "my first son in the Igbo family gets all the privilege" thing—I didn't have the energy to fight it. I had more important things to think about, like how to go from barely passing my entrance exams to mastering school content. That's what informed the friends I made: Tolu Odunola, Roseben Anyanwu, Ibukun Olujumi—the people in class who embodied the type of students you wanted us to be.

I said okay and was grateful you were sponsoring my education and taking me out of Nigeria. But I was confused.

****About Chinazo and Ogoma—****

On finances, I think you owe Chinazo and Ogoma an apology. I always found it unfair that the sons got to study abroad first. Had that short-sighted policy not been made, they might have done well enough early enough to ease you of the burden of financing your sons' education abroad.

They never mention it, but I suspect this is a good reason why Chinazo is disappointed with Mummy—that she gave in to her premodern notions of gender roles and treated the girls like second-class children.

****About my sexuality, depression, and suicidality—****

These are things I've firmly decided I am solely responsible for. Any help is appreciated, but as an adult, this is my burden to carry. It would be good for our relationship to not center on it. Honestly, it's not anyone's business.

I read your message about not understanding why gay people are more suicidal. You wrote that if someone is unhappy being gay, they can simply choose not to be gay, the way people choose celibacy to become priests or nuns.

Daddy, it doesn't work that way. Gay people aren't more suicidal because they're unhappy with being gay. They're more suicidal because of how the world treats them—rejection from family, condemnation from religion, discrimination, violence, the constant message that something is fundamentally wrong with them. The pressure comes from outside, not inside.

If you ever want to understand this better, please read **Prayers for Bobby**. It's the true story of a gay man who killed himself under pressure from ultra-religious parents. After he died, his mother spent the rest of her life fighting for the rights gay men now have in America. It might help you see what I mean.

But I want to be clear about something else: if I am depressed or suicidal, it is not primarily because of being gay. It is because I am extremely hard on myself. I see the privilege I have received, and I know that much more is expected of me.

When I compare myself to my closest friends, I see what people can achieve with far less:

Douglas Kendyson—raised by a single mother, the father figure and head of his family, working relentlessly to put his sisters through school.

Kunle Ologunro—went through university with only a breaking-down phone, from which he started his illustrious writing career. He comes from a massively dysfunctional and poor family by our standards, with a father who still depends on him financially and a mother doing her best selling pure water and drinks in Lagos. He was raised by his grandmother and shuffled between homes.

These are my friends. This is what they've overcome. And when I measure myself against what they've built with what they were given versus what I've built with what I was given, I know I have a lot of work to do. If I ever feel like killing myself, it is because I am nowhere close to what is expected of me given what I have received.

****Finally—****

You wrote that the Bible tells us to forgive 70 times 7 times, but each dart leaves a scar on the board. That words once spoken cannot truly be taken back.

I know. I am working on controlling my emotions and preventing outbursts. I will continue to work on that.

But I also want you to understand that some of what I carry isn't an outburst—it's years of quiet observation and disappointment that I've never had the chance to explain.

I'm explaining it now. Not to wound you, but so you know where your son actually stands.

I told you yesterday that if I had married you on your potential the way your wife did, and you became the man you did, I would have left you long ago. That is true. And I am grateful you have raised daughters who will not put up with that nonsense in their husbands.

But please remember: your children are still your children. We love you. I love you. My only desire has been that you be happy in life. It's just that—well, you're not. And it's frustrating that personally I am too incompetent to help.

Your son,
Dozie

Let me know if there's anything else you'd like to adjust.